In the wake of the terrorist attack on the Army Public School on 16 December 2014, in which 145 students and teachers were killed, the government lifted a six-year moratorium on executions (*The New York Times*, 22 December 2014). As a result, more than 300 prisoners were hanged in 2015 and 2016 under a new military judicial system.

COUNTERING TERRORISM

The state response to terrorism in urban centres mostly remained weak and disjointed. The lack of counter-terrorism strategy confirmed the absence of the will of the government to tackle the terrorists in a firm, coordinated and effective manner. Lack of political will had a trickle-down effect on the government departments responsible to counter-terrorism. The police and their intelligence set-ups were deficient in temperament, training, experience, paraphernalia and, at times, will to tackle this sort of terrorism. Immediately after the attack on the Sri Lankan cricket team in Lahore in March 2009, the Inspector General of Police, Punjab, stated that countering terrorism was not a police job.

As the suicide attacks generally emanated from FATA and Swat, outside the respective provinces and areas, it became difficult for the provincial set-ups to pre-empt and prevent them. It required relentless coordination of the provincial police/intelligence set-ups with the federal intelligence agencies like the Intelligence Bureau (IB) and ISI to have advance information originating from FATA and elsewhere. This coordination was patchy and inconsistent.

Generally, the police took the forewarnings, with indicators and insinuations provided by the federal agencies, lightly. They resented the paucity of information provided to them and failed to convince them to take action on it. Unfortunately, at times, these information reports turned true.

The police investigations into suicide attacks were most often found to be too insipid and incomplete. Consequently, the courts exonerated a number of perpetrators and they re-joined their militant groups to continue with future actions.

The dispersal and destruction of the militants in Swat resulted in a lull in suicide terrorism. Nipping the perpetrators in their areas was a good counter-terrorism strategy. However, it was not done properly. The death of Baitullah and the operation against TTP in Waziristan